Foreword

At the outset, I would like to congratulate Flight Lieutenant Gunjan Saxena (retd) for writing her autobiography, as she has been a pathbreaker in her field! Being among the first few women officers who were given commission in the Flying Branch, she fought an uphill battle to break the stereotype of an Indian woman! Being part of the second course of women officers selected for helicopter-flying, she was assigned to a Cheetah/Chetak (Alouette III) unit in Udhampur, whose primary task was forward air control, which was to fly in the thick of combat during the erstwhile close air support/battlefield air strike (BAS) missions and visually guiding fighter aircraft to their targets.

In her book, Gunjan has successfully explained what it takes to become an officer in the Indian Air Force. Her retelling of the Kargil War made me go down memory lane and reminded me of my own experience in the war, wherein I was commanding 17 Squadron (Golden Arrows), where we worked closely with 132 FAC flight for all our BAS missions in the Kashmir Valley. During the Kargil conflict, as the main mode of attack had shifted to GPS-aided bombing from the classic BAS, Gunjan's unit provided vital information about where our bombs were dropping relative to the target.

Post the ceasefire of sorts, her task was to carry me and the commanding officer of 108 Squadron for a recce sortie of the target area and a visit to 3 and 8 Division Headquarters at their operational locations. I was pleasantly surprised to see a calm and confident lady officer toting an AK-47 as her weapon in the Cheetah helicopter! In Kargil, I also happened to meet her brother Captain Anshuman Saxena of the Army Ordnance Corps. I asked them if their parents were on tenterhooks as both their children were deployed in the battle zone! The answer was a nonchalant no!